

After college, Bud took a job with a major stock brokerage firm. He was a fast learner and had a pleasant personality, and he did quite well. But within a few years Sandi feared she was seeing the same attitudes developing in Bud that she had seen in her father. Bud was consumed by business and had a drive to succeed that pushed everything and everyone else into the background.

Sandi began to complain to Bud about his lack of care for his family and his noninvolvement in their lives.

The more Sandi protested, the less Bud knew how to handle it, so he began to substitute time at the office for time with her. As his income grew, so did opportunities to take part in some of the investments his company brokered. He began to risk larger amounts of borrowed money, secured only by his signature.

Within a few years, Bud's net worth had grown to a handsome six-figure number, and with it grew his ability to borrow even more. He bought a million-dollar home in a wealthy neighborhood—despite Sandi's objections.

Bud even made several attempts to spend more time at home, but too often another deal would develop, and he would spend weeks of sixteen-hour days putting it together. When she saw the volumes of forms that had to be filed with their tax statements each year, Sandi asked Bud to sit down and discuss their finances. Bud said he would, but he never took the time to do so. He knew that Sandi wouldn't agree with many of the things he was doing, so it was just easier to avoid telling her.

As time passed, Sandi felt more and more excluded from what had become the focus of Bud's activities. All she knew about their finances was how much Bud gave her to run the household. He was extremely generous, and Sandi usually got whatever she asked for.

Then suddenly the economy, which had been inflating the real estate ventures Bud was handling, cooled off. Interest rates for speculative real-estate deals rose precipitously. The real estate market that had grown as a result of borrowed money suddenly stopped cold.